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contribution to the GDP is only about 17 per cent, it still employs about 60 per cent of our population. For India, agriculture development will always be at the core of any rural development initiative. It is thus important to look at agriculture not only from the point of view of food security, but also as an agent for inclusive economic growth.

I have always visualised agricultural growth and in that context the need for a second Green Revolution from three different perspectives—political and social, economic and, food and nutrition.

The Government is committed to achieving inclusive growth. The highly skewed nature of our income distribution needs to be addressed to ensure that the aspirations of those living in the rural areas are met. A significant increase in their income to allow them access to the best in education, health-care and other comforts can only occur if we

“PARKASH SINGH BADAL Chief Minister, Punjab

Punjab has 1.5 per cent of the land of India but it takes care of 40 per cent of rice and more than 40 per cent of wheat requirement of the country. But we are like beggars before the Centre. The Centre decides on its own prices of agricultural produce and the states have no choice but to accept them whereas the cost of inputs like diesel or pesticides, etc is rising. Nobody has realised what sacrifice Punjab has made for the country. Multi-cropping has devastated our land, groundwater levels have gone deep down, our farmers have put everything in agriculture. So in return, we expect a better deal for the sacrifice we have made. Our canal system needs rejuvenation but we have no money.”



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are able to multiply manifold our achievements in the agricultural sector and also accommodate those living on the margins. Any failure on this account will lead to rising social and political unrest, especially amongst the youth. The simple solution of increasing the prices of farm produce, as propagated by some, has its own limitations. We must remember, that such an increase translates into higher prices for consumers and it is the Government's bounden duty to strike a bal-